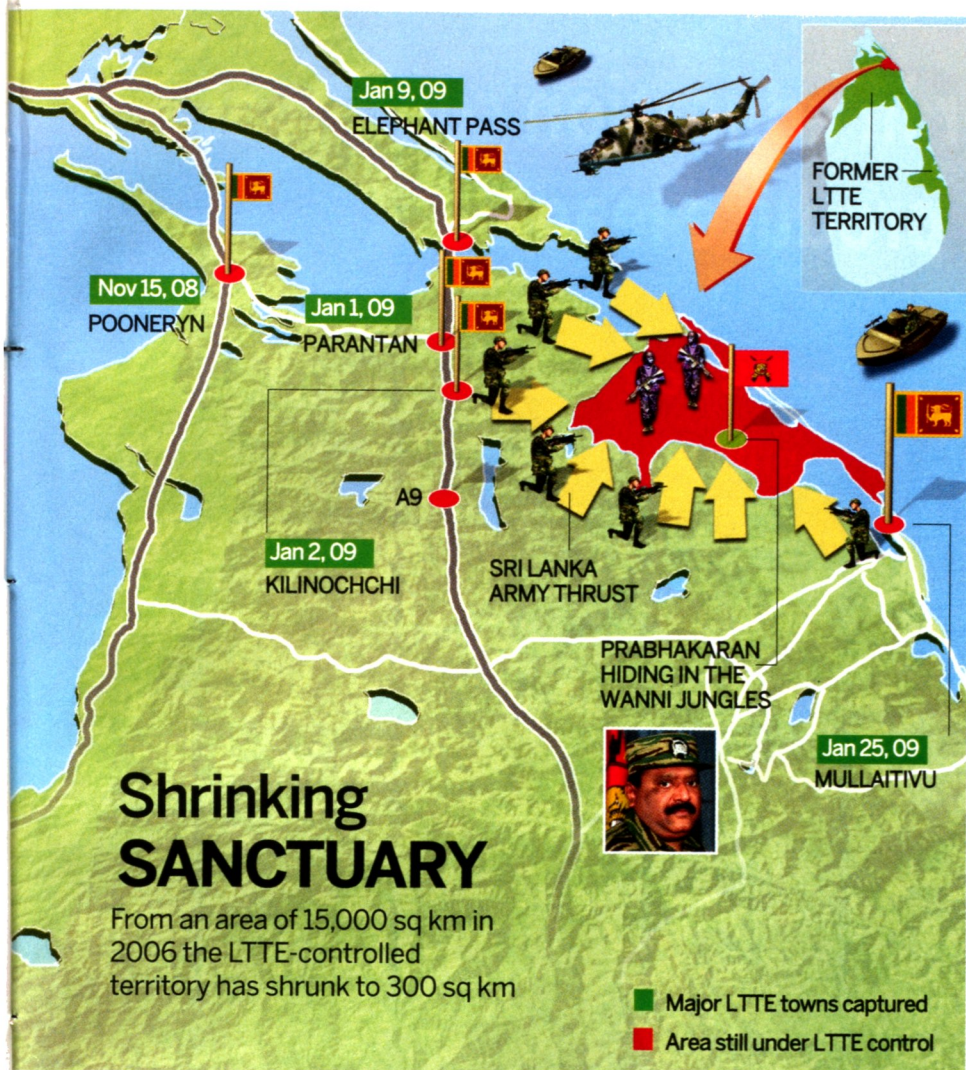




INDIA'S WORRY IS THE **FALLOUT IN TAMIL NADU** AND THE DEVOLUTION PACKAGE NEEDED TO BRING PEACE.



Indian High Commission said.

While Mukherjee's visit is seen in Sri Lanka as a pre-election bid to appease restive politicians in Tamil Nadu who are calling for more Indian intervention in the island's crisis, the Government here is talking of a new phase in Indo-Lanka relations. Delhi's support is crucial for Lanka and Mukherjee promised Indian aid in the reconstruction of the war-ravaged north. Analysts expect Rajapakse to now offer the ethnic Tamil community a political package that will devolve power to the newly-liberated provinces in a bid to appease Tamil hardliners. The Indian High Commission statement said that Rajapakse had told Mukherjee that he would implement the 13th amend-

ment to the Constitution which decrees the establishment of provincial councils as per the provisions of the Indo-Lanka Accord of 1987. The agreement, however, spoke of a merged north-east province, while under a Supreme Court ruling in 2007, the two provinces are demerged with the eastern province having its own provincial council. Mukherjee's statement said that Rajapakse "would explore the possibility of going further and improving upon those devolution proposals".

However, offering anything more than the powers already devolved will make it difficult for the Lankan President to win support from Sinhala hawks who have been staunch backers of his anti-LTTE offensive. On the

back of the military victories, two key provincial polls are due next month and there is speculation of a general election to give Rajapakse's United People's Freedom Alliance a better grip on the legislature. In this scenario, Rajapakse is unlikely to risk alienating his Sinhala electorate with extensive concessions to the Tamils. Therein lies Rajapakse's dilemma. If he allows triumphalism to prevail, then the Tamils would remain discontented and that may sow the seeds of the next cycle of violence and retribution. The situation calls for extraordinary statesmanship. Having all but triumphed in the war, Rajapakse must now demonstrate that he has it in him to bring lasting peace in Sri Lanka. ■